

Draft Spot vs Season Results

The Darling league, 2017-2025 draft boards with populated pick data (92 team-seasons).

Bottom line: draft slot has signal in this history, but not in the expected direction. Across the populated data, raw pick number has a -0.21 correlation with final finish, and each later pick maps to about -0.21 finishing places on the simple trend line, meaning later picks have finished slightly better. Normalized for league size, moving from the front to the back of the draft is associated with a +0.22 change in finish score. The points relationship is much flatter: +0.09 points z-score and +0.11 wins versus league average from front to back.

How to read the normalized metrics

Finish score runs from 1.00 for champion to 0.00 for last place within that season. Points z-score compares a team's points for to that season's league average, which prevents older lower-scoring years and the 12-team 2025 season from overweighting the comparison. Wins +/- is wins plus half-ties compared with the average team in that season.

Key findings

1. The best average normalized finish belongs to pick 11 (avg score 1.00, n=1); the weakest is pick 3 (avg score 0.37, n=9). Among the repeat-sample slots, pick 10 is the standout: three champions, a 78% playoff rate, and the best average finish.
2. Championships are not concentrated at the top of the board. Early picks 1-3 have one title in the sample, middle picks 4-7 have three, and late picks 8+ have five. That late count includes the 2025 pick 11 champion, but the pattern still leans late even if 2025 is removed.
3. Early slots have not converted into superior outcomes. Picks 1-3 have the lowest zone-level finish score, the lowest playoff rate, and the highest Saunders rate. That does not mean early picks are bad structurally, but this league's history does not show a front-slot premium.
4. The 12-team 2025 season does not drive the conclusion by itself. Restricting the analysis to the 10-team seasons from 2017-2024 still gives a front-to-back finish-score slope of +0.21, and the late zone posts a 71% playoff rate with 4 champions.
5. Pick-level sample sizes are small. Most slots have nine observations, while 2025 adds only one observation for picks 11 and 12. Treat single-slot rankings as descriptive league history, not a predictive model.

Draft Slot vs Final Finish

Each dot is a team-season. Lower finish number is better; gold dots are champions.

Correlation: $r=-0.21$ | Trend: -0.21 finish places per pick

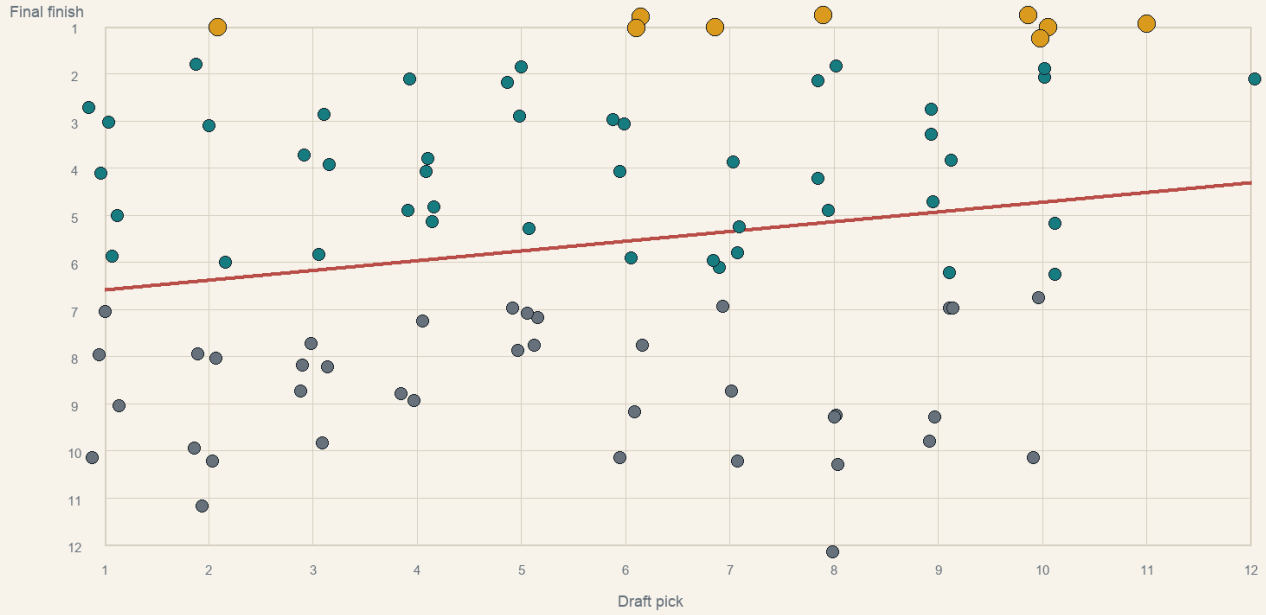


Figure 1. Scatter plot of draft pick against final finish with a linear trend line.

Slot-Level Performance

This chart compares average normalized finish by pick and overlays points performance. A high bar means the pick generally finished better; a higher gold dot means teams from that pick scored more points than the season average.

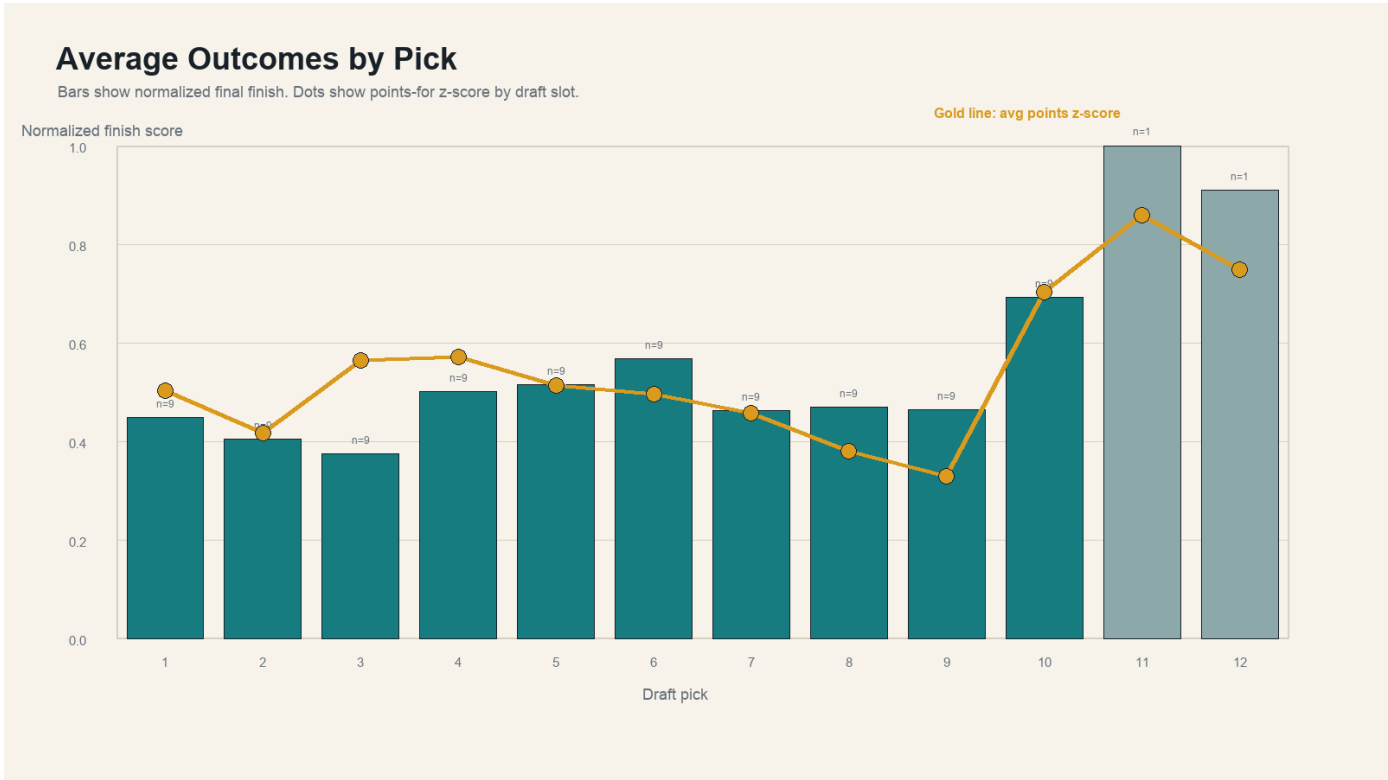


Figure 2. Average finish score and points z-score by draft slot.

Outcome Rates by Zone

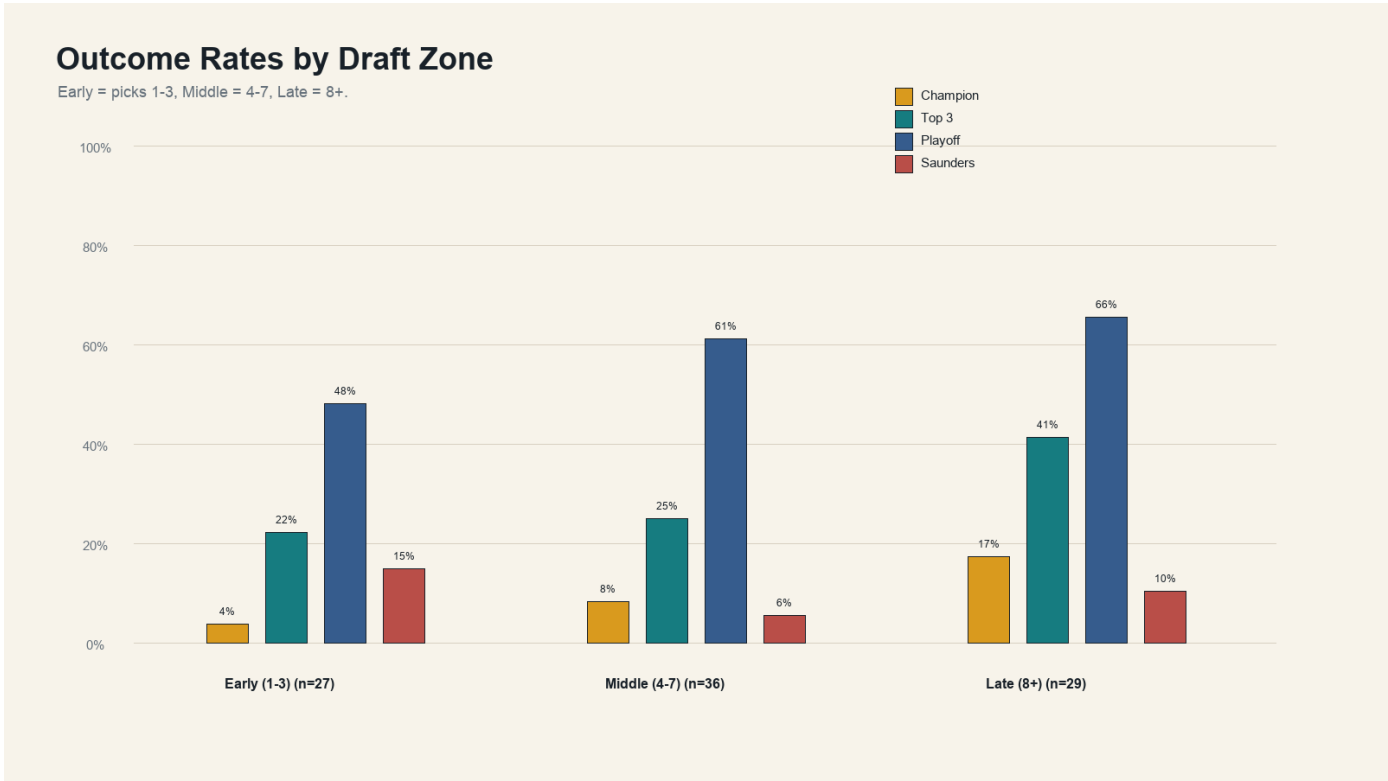


Figure 3. Championship, top-three, playoff, and Saunders rates by draft zone.

Distribution Views

The heatmap is useful for spotting whether any draft position repeatedly landed in the same finish range. The lack of a single dark diagonal reinforces the main conclusion: draft position matters less than team-specific execution and season variance.

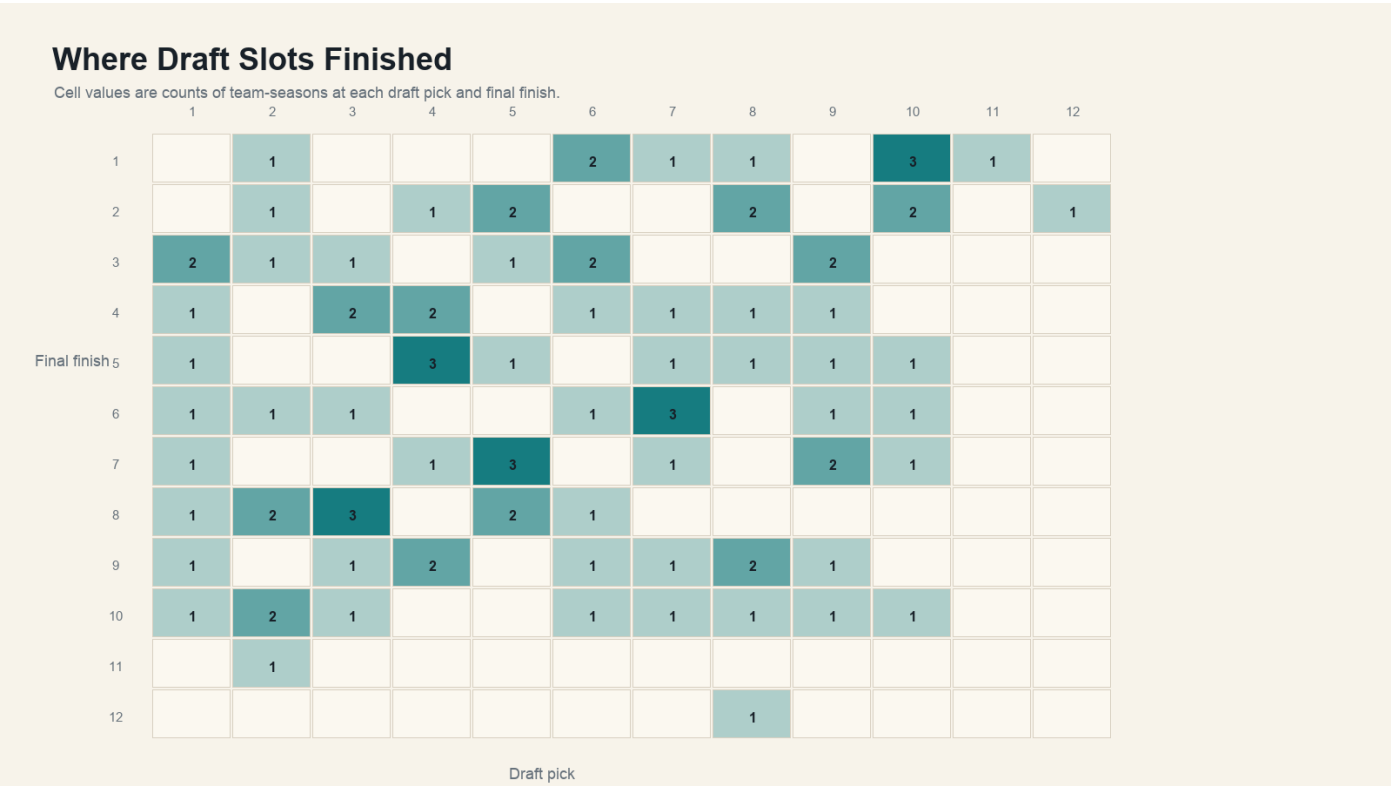


Figure 4. Count of pick-to-finish combinations.

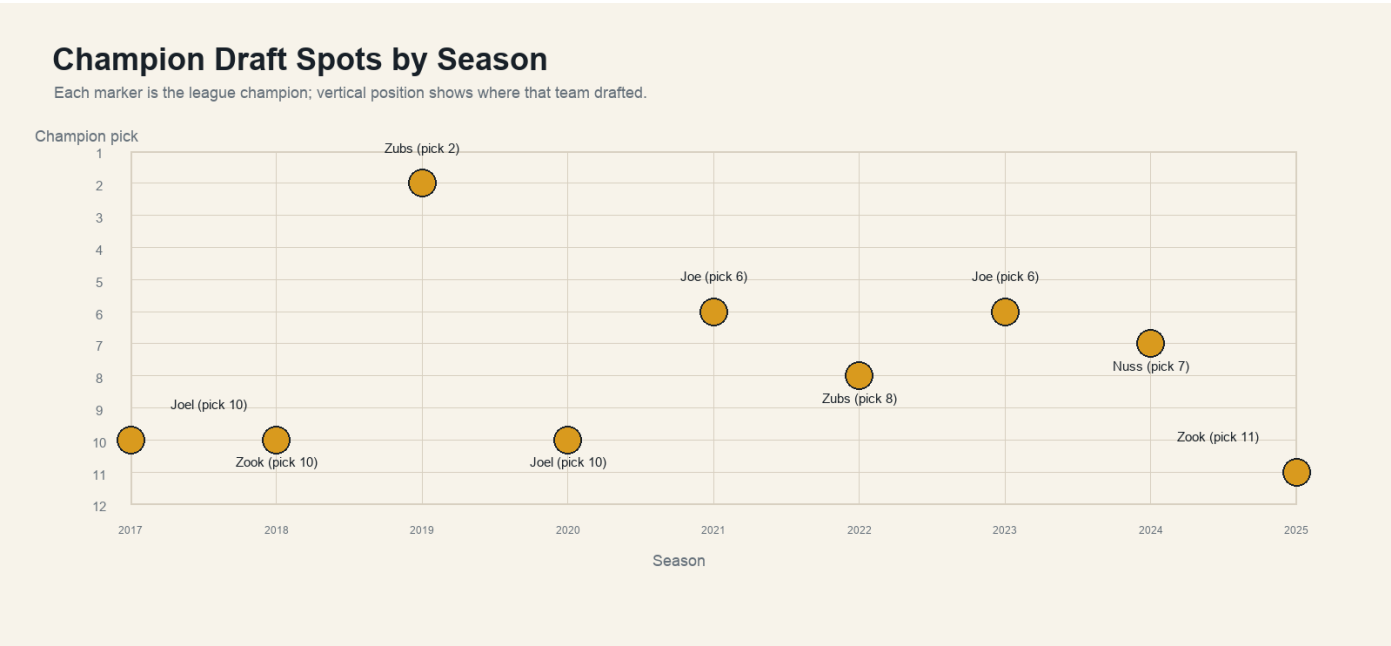


Figure 5. Champion draft positions by season.

Owner-Specific Draft Targets

The league-wide pattern is useful, but the actionable version changes by owner. This section compares each owner's own draft slots and zones, then separates repeat-sample evidence from one-year outliers.

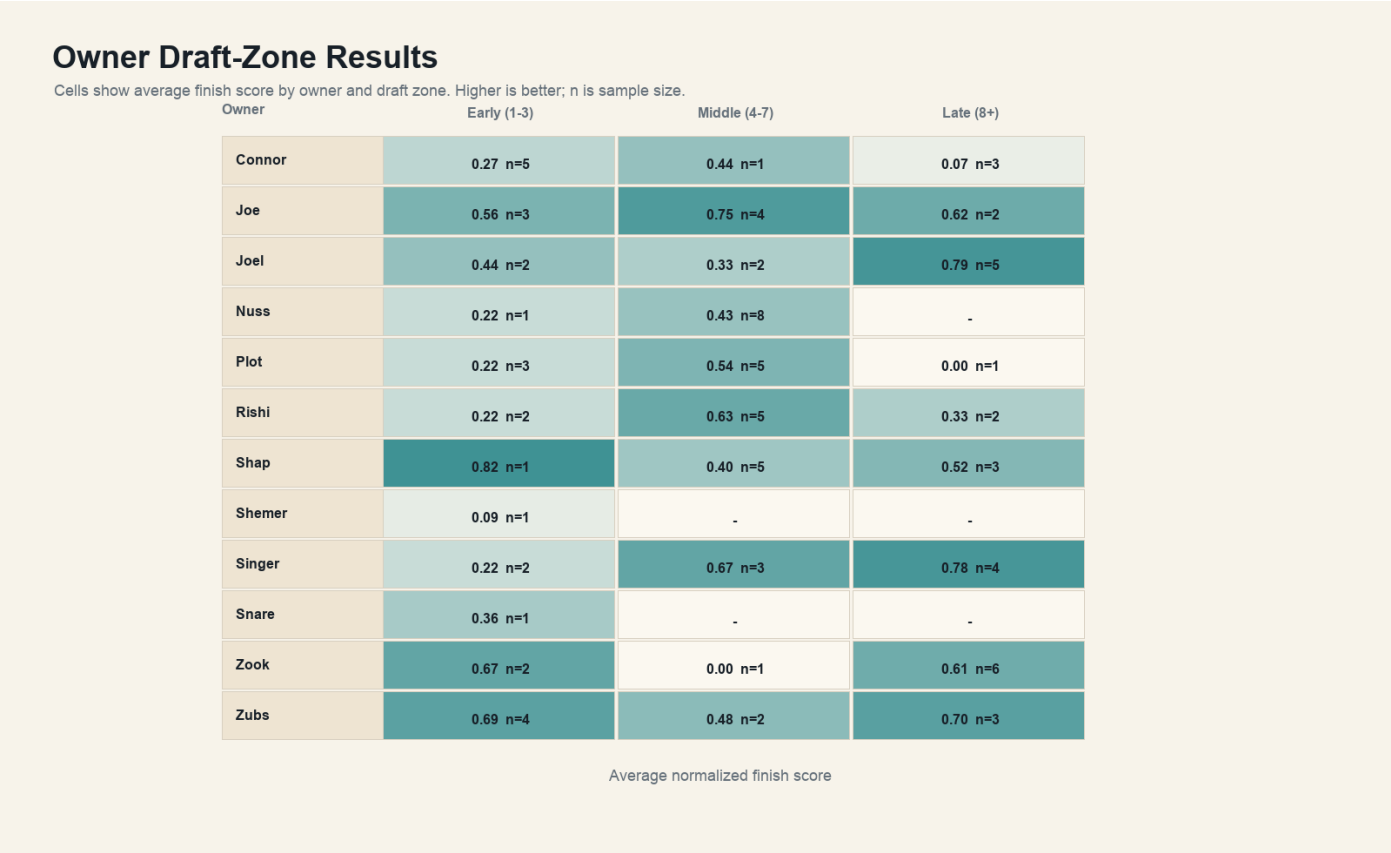


Figure 6. Owner results by early, middle, and late draft zones.

Owner Target Summary

Owner	Target	Best Evidence	Caution
Connor	Pick 7 upside; Early (1-3) repeat zone	Pick 7: n=1, avg finish 6.0, playoffs 1/1, top 3 0/1, titles 0. Best zone: Middle (4-7): n=1, avg finish 6.0, playoffs 1/1, top 3 0/1, titles 0.	Weakest area: Late (8+) (avg finish 10.0, n=3).
Joe	Pick 6	Pick 9: n=1, avg finish 3.0, playoffs 1/1, top 3 1/1, titles 0. Best zone: Middle (4-7): n=4, avg finish 3.2, playoffs 3/4, top 3 3/4, titles 2.	Weakest area: Early (1-3) (avg finish 5.0, n=3).
Joel	Pick 10	Pick 10: n=4, avg finish 1.5, playoffs 4/4, top 3 4/4, titles 2. Best zone: Late (8+): n=5, avg finish 3.2, playoffs 4/5, top 3 4/5, titles 2.	Weakest area: Middle (4-7) (avg finish 7.0, n=2).
Nuss	Middle (4-7)	Pick 7: n=2, avg finish 5.5, playoffs 1/2, top 3 1/2, titles 1. Best zone: Middle (4-7): n=8, avg finish 6.2, playoffs 4/8, top 3 2/8, titles 1.	Weakest area: Early (1-3) (avg finish 8.0, n=1).
Plot	Middle (4-7)	Pick 4: n=2, avg finish 3.0, playoffs 2/2, top 3 1/2, titles 0. Best zone: Middle (4-7): n=5, avg finish 5.4, playoffs 3/5, top 3 1/5, titles 0.	Weakest area: Late (8+) (avg finish 10.0, n=1).
Rishi	Pick 5 upside; Middle (4-7) repeat zone	Pick 5: n=1, avg finish 2.0, playoffs 1/1, top 3 1/1, titles 0. Best zone: Middle (4-7): n=5, avg finish 4.4, playoffs 5/5, top 3 1/5, titles 0.	Weakest area: Early (1-3) (avg finish 8.0, n=2).
Shap	Pick 3 upside; Late (8+) repeat zone	Pick 3: n=1, avg finish 3.0, playoffs 1/1, top 3 1/1, titles 0. Best zone: Early (1-3): n=1, avg finish 3.0, playoffs 1/1, top 3 1/1, titles 0.	Weakest area: Middle (4-7) (avg finish 6.4, n=5).
Shemer	Insufficient owner sample; observed pick 2	Pick 2: n=1, avg finish 11.0, playoffs 0/1, top 3 0/1, titles 0. Best zone: Early (1-3): n=1, avg finish 11.0, playoffs 0/1, top 3 0/1, titles 0.	No clear avoid zone yet. Sample is too small for a firm owner-specific read.
Singer	Pick 12 upside; Late (8+) repeat zone	Pick 12: n=1, avg finish 2.0, playoffs 1/1, top 3 1/1, titles 0. Best zone: Late (8+): n=4, avg finish 3.0, playoffs 4/4, top 3 3/4, titles 0.	Weakest area: Early (1-3) (avg finish 8.0, n=2).
Snare	Insufficient owner sample; observed pick 1	Pick 1: n=1, avg finish 8.0, playoffs 0/1, top 3 0/1, titles 0. Best zone: Early (1-3): n=1, avg finish 8.0, playoffs 0/1, top 3 0/1, titles 0.	No clear avoid zone yet. Sample is too small for a firm owner-specific read.
Zook	Pick 10 upside; Early (1-3) repeat zone	Pick 10: n=1, avg finish 1.0, playoffs 1/1, top 3 1/1, titles 1. Best zone: Early (1-3): n=2, avg finish 4.0, playoffs 2/2, top 3 1/2, titles 0.	Weakest area: Middle (4-7) (avg finish 10.0, n=1).
Zubs	Pick 2	Pick 8: n=1, avg finish 1.0, playoffs 1/1, top 3 1/1, titles 1. Best zone: Late (8+): n=3, avg finish 3.7, playoffs 2/3, top 3 2/3, titles 1.	Weakest area: Middle (4-7) (avg finish 6.0, n=2).

Owner Detail Notes

Connor

Recommendation	Best result is Pick 7 in Middle (4-7), but that zone only has one sample. The best repeat area is Early (1-3) (avg finish 7.6, n=5).
Best Pick(s)	Pick 7: n=1, avg finish 6.0, playoffs 1/1, top 3 0/1, titles 0; Pick 2: n=4, avg finish 7.2, playoffs 2/4, top 3 1/4, titles 0; Pick 1: n=1, avg finish 9.0, playoffs 0/1, top 3 0/1, titles 0; Pick 8: n=3, avg finish 10.0, playoffs 0/3, top 3 0/3, titles 0
Zone Read	Middle (4-7): n=1, avg finish 6.0, playoffs 1/1, top 3 0/1, titles 0; Early (1-3): n=5, avg finish 7.6, playoffs 2/5, top 3 1/5, titles 0; Late (8+): n=3, avg finish 10.0, playoffs 0/3, top 3 0/3, titles 0
Caution	Weakest area: Late (8+) (avg finish 10.0, n=3).
History	2017: p2, f10 Saunders; 2018: p2, f10 Saunders; 2019: p8, f9; 2020: p7, f6; 2021: p8, f9; 2022: p2, f6; 2023: p2, f3; 2024: p1, f9; 2025: p8, f12 Saunders

Joe

Recommendation	Target Pick 6 specifically. It has the strongest repeat sample: avg finish 3.2, playoffs 3/4, titles 2.
Best Pick(s)	Pick 9: n=1, avg finish 3.0, playoffs 1/1, top 3 1/1, titles 0; Pick 6: n=4, avg finish 3.2, playoffs 3/4, top 3 3/4, titles 2; Pick 3: n=1, avg finish 4.0, playoffs 1/1, top 3 0/1, titles 0; Pick 1: n=2, avg finish 5.5, playoffs 1/2, top 3 0/2, titles 0; Pick 10: n=1, avg finish 7.0, playoffs 0/1, top 3 0/1, titles 0
Zone Read	Middle (4-7): n=4, avg finish 3.2, playoffs 3/4, top 3 3/4, titles 2; Late (8+): n=2, avg finish 5.0, playoffs 1/2, top 3 1/2, titles 0; Early (1-3): n=3, avg finish 5.0, playoffs 2/3, top 3 0/3, titles 0
Caution	Weakest area: Early (1-3) (avg finish 5.0, n=3).
History	2017: p3, f4; 2018: p1, f7; 2019: p6, f8; 2020: p6, f3; 2021: p6, f1 champ; 2022: p1, f4; 2023: p6, f1 champ; 2024: p9, f3; 2025: p10, f7

Joel

Recommendation	Target Pick 10 specifically. It has the strongest repeat sample: avg finish 1.5, playoffs 4/4, titles 2.
Best Pick(s)	Pick 10: n=4, avg finish 1.5, playoffs 4/4, top 3 4/4, titles 2; Pick 1: n=1, avg finish 3.0, playoffs 1/1, top 3 1/1, titles 0; Pick 4: n=2, avg finish 7.0, playoffs 1/2, top 3 0/2, titles 0; Pick 9: n=1, avg finish 10.0, playoffs 0/1, top 3 0/1, titles 0; Pick 3: n=1, avg finish 9.0, playoffs 0/1, top 3 0/1, titles 0
Zone Read	Late (8+): n=5, avg finish 3.2, playoffs 4/5, top 3 4/5, titles 2; Early (1-3): n=2, avg finish 6.0, playoffs 1/2, top 3 1/2, titles 0; Middle (4-7): n=2, avg finish 7.0, playoffs 1/2, top 3 0/2, titles 0
Caution	Weakest area: Middle (4-7) (avg finish 7.0, n=2).
History	2017: p10, f1 champ; 2018: p3, f9; 2019: p1, f3; 2020: p10, f1 champ; 2021: p10, f2; 2022: p4, f9; 2023: p10, f2; 2024: p4, f5; 2025: p9, f10

Nuss

Recommendation	Target Middle (4-7). It is this owner's best zone: avg finish 6.2, playoffs 4/8, titles 1.
Best Pick(s)	Pick 7: n=2, avg finish 5.5, playoffs 1/2, top 3 1/2, titles 1; Pick 6: n=3, avg finish 6.0, playoffs 2/3, top 3 1/3, titles 0; Pick 4: n=3, avg finish 7.0, playoffs 1/3, top 3 0/3, titles 0; Pick 2: n=1, avg finish 8.0, playoffs 0/1, top 3 0/1, titles 0
Zone Read	Middle (4-7): n=8, avg finish 6.2, playoffs 4/8, top 3 2/8, titles 1; Early (1-3): n=1, avg finish 8.0, playoffs 0/1, top 3 0/1, titles 0
Caution	Weakest area: Early (1-3) (avg finish 8.0, n=1).
History	2017: p6, f9; 2018: p4, f5; 2019: p7, f10 Saunders; 2020: p2, f8; 2021: p4, f7; 2022: p6, f3; 2023: p4, f9; 2024: p7, f1 champ; 2025: p6, f6

Plot

Recommendation	Target Middle (4-7). It is this owner's best zone: avg finish 5.4, playoffs 3/5, titles 0.
Best Pick(s)	Pick 4: n=2, avg finish 3.0, playoffs 2/2, top 3 1/2, titles 0; Pick 6: n=1, avg finish 4.0, playoffs 1/1, top 3 0/1, titles 0; Pick 1: n=1, avg finish 6.0, playoffs 1/1, top 3 0/1, titles 0; Pick 7: n=1, avg finish 9.0, playoffs 0/1, top 3 0/1, titles 0; Pick 5: n=1, avg finish 8.0, playoffs 0/1, top 3 0/1, titles 0; Pick 3: n=2, avg finish 9.0, playoffs 0/2, top 3 0/2, titles 0; Pick 10: n=1, avg finish 10.0, playoffs 0/1, top 3 0/1, titles 0
Zone Read	Middle (4-7): n=5, avg finish 5.4, playoffs 3/5, top 3 1/5, titles 0; Early (1-3): n=3, avg finish 8.0, playoffs 1/3, top 3 0/3, titles 0; Late (8+): n=1, avg finish 10.0, playoffs 0/1, top 3 0/1, titles 0
Caution	Weakest area: Late (8+) (avg finish 10.0, n=1).
History	2017: p5, f8; 2018: p6, f4; 2019: p4, f4; 2020: p4, f2; 2021: p3, f10 Saunders; 2022: p10, f10 Saunders; 2023: p1, f6; 2024: p3, f8; 2025: p7, f9

Rishi

Recommendation	Best single result is Pick 5, but the sturdier area is Middle (4-7) (avg finish 4.4, n=5).
Best Pick(s)	Pick 5: n=1, avg finish 2.0, playoffs 1/1, top 3 1/1, titles 0; Pick 4: n=1, avg finish 4.0, playoffs 1/1, top 3 0/1, titles 0; Pick 7: n=3, avg finish 5.3, playoffs 3/3, top 3 0/3, titles 0; Pick 3: n=1, avg finish 6.0, playoffs 1/1, top 3 0/1, titles 0; Pick 8: n=2, avg finish 7.0, playoffs 1/2, top 3 0/2, titles 0; Pick 1: n=1, avg finish 10.0, playoffs 0/1, top 3 0/1, titles 0
Zone Read	Middle (4-7): n=5, avg finish 4.4, playoffs 5/5, top 3 1/5, titles 0; Late (8+): n=2, avg finish 7.0, playoffs 1/2, top 3 0/2, titles 0; Early (1-3): n=2, avg finish 8.0, playoffs 1/2, top 3 0/2, titles 0
Caution	Weakest area: Early (1-3) (avg finish 8.0, n=2).
History	2017: p7, f6; 2018: p7, f6; 2019: p3, f6; 2020: p1, f10 Saunders; 2021: p7, f4; 2022: p5, f2; 2023: p8, f10 Saunders; 2024: p8, f4; 2025: p4, f4

Shap

Recommendation	Best result is Pick 3 in Early (1-3), but that zone only has one sample. The best repeat area is Late (8+) (avg finish 5.3, n=3).
Best Pick(s)	Pick 3: n=1, avg finish 3.0, playoffs 1/1, top 3 1/1, titles 0; Pick 10: n=1, avg finish 5.0, playoffs 1/1, top 3 0/1, titles 0; Pick 4: n=1, avg finish 5.0, playoffs 1/1, top 3 0/1, titles 0; Pick 8: n=1, avg finish 5.0, playoffs 1/1, top 3 0/1, titles 0; Pick 7: n=2, avg finish 6.0, playoffs 1/2, top 3 0/2, titles 0; Pick 9: n=1, avg finish 6.0, playoffs 1/1, top 3 0/1, titles 0; Pick 5: n=2, avg finish 7.5, playoffs 0/2, top 3 0/2, titles 0
Zone Read	Early (1-3): n=1, avg finish 3.0, playoffs 1/1, top 3 1/1, titles 0; Late (8+): n=3, avg finish 5.3, playoffs 3/3, top 3 0/3, titles 0; Middle (4-7): n=5, avg finish 6.4, playoffs 2/5, top 3 0/5, titles 0
Caution	Weakest area: Middle (4-7) (avg finish 6.4, n=5).
History	2017: p4, f5; 2018: p5, f8; 2019: p10, f5; 2020: p8, f5; 2021: p9, f6; 2022: p7, f7; 2023: p7, f5; 2024: p5, f7; 2025: p3, f3

Shemer

Recommendation	Only one data point: pick 2 in 2025, finish 11. Use league-wide history more than owner-specific history.
Best Pick(s)	Pick 2: n=1, avg finish 11.0, playoffs 0/1, top 3 0/1, titles 0
Zone Read	Early (1-3): n=1, avg finish 11.0, playoffs 0/1, top 3 0/1, titles 0
Caution	No clear avoid zone yet. Sample is too small for a firm owner-specific read.
History	2025: p2, f11

Singer

Recommendation	Best single result is Pick 12, but the sturdier area is Late (8+) (avg finish 3.0, n=4).
Best Pick(s)	Pick 12: n=1, avg finish 2.0, playoffs 1/1, top 3 1/1, titles 0; Pick 8: n=2, avg finish 2.0, playoffs 2/2, top 3 2/2, titles 0; Pick 5: n=3, avg finish 4.0, playoffs 2/3, top 3 2/3, titles 0; Pick 10: n=1, avg finish 6.0, playoffs 1/1, top 3 0/1, titles 0; Pick 3: n=2, avg finish 8.0, playoffs 0/2, top 3 0/2, titles 0
Zone Read	Late (8+): n=4, avg finish 3.0, playoffs 4/4, top 3 3/4, titles 0; Middle (4-7): n=3, avg finish 4.0, playoffs 2/3, top 3 2/3, titles 0; Early (1-3): n=2, avg finish 8.0, playoffs 0/2, top 3 0/2, titles 0
Caution	Weakest area: Early (1-3) (avg finish 8.0, n=2).
History	2017: p8, f2; 2018: p8, f2; 2019: p5, f2; 2020: p5, f7; 2021: p5, f3; 2022: p3, f8; 2023: p3, f8; 2024: p10, f6; 2025: p12, f2

Snare

Recommendation	Only one data point: pick 1 in 2025, finish 8. Use league-wide history more than owner-specific history.
Best Pick(s)	Pick 1: n=1, avg finish 8.0, playoffs 0/1, top 3 0/1, titles 0
Zone Read	Early (1-3): n=1, avg finish 8.0, playoffs 0/1, top 3 0/1, titles 0
Caution	No clear avoid zone yet. Sample is too small for a firm owner-specific read.
History	2025: p1, f8

Zook

Recommendation	Best single result is Pick 10, but the sturdier area is Early (1-3) (avg finish 4.0, n=2).
Best Pick(s)	Pick 10: n=1, avg finish 1.0, playoffs 1/1, top 3 1/1, titles 1; Pick 11: n=1, avg finish 1.0, playoffs 1/1, top 3 1/1, titles 1; Pick 1: n=2, avg finish 4.0, playoffs 2/2, top 3 1/2, titles 0; Pick 9: n=4, avg finish 6.2, playoffs 2/4, top 3 0/4, titles 0; Pick 6: n=1, avg finish 10.0, playoffs 0/1, top 3 0/1, titles 0
Zone Read	Early (1-3): n=2, avg finish 4.0, playoffs 2/2, top 3 1/2, titles 0; Late (8+): n=6, avg finish 4.5, playoffs 4/6, top 3 2/6, titles 2; Middle (4-7): n=1, avg finish 10.0, playoffs 0/1, top 3 0/1, titles 0
Caution	Weakest area: Middle (4-7) (avg finish 10.0, n=1).
History	2017: p1, f3; 2018: p10, f1 champ; 2019: p9, f7; 2020: p9, f9; 2021: p1, f5; 2022: p9, f5; 2023: p9, f4; 2024: p6, f10 Saunders; 2025: p11, f1 champ

Zubs

Recommendation	Target Pick 2 specifically. It has the strongest repeat sample: avg finish 3.7, playoffs 2/3, titles 1.
Best Pick(s)	Pick 8: n=1, avg finish 1.0, playoffs 1/1, top 3 1/1, titles 1; Pick 2: n=3, avg finish 3.7, playoffs 2/3, top 3 2/3, titles 1; Pick 3: n=1, avg finish 4.0, playoffs 1/1, top 3 0/1, titles 0; Pick 9: n=2, avg finish 5.0, playoffs 1/2, top 3 1/2, titles 0; Pick 5: n=2, avg finish 6.0, playoffs 1/2, top 3 0/2, titles 0
Zone Read	Late (8+): n=3, avg finish 3.7, playoffs 2/3, top 3 2/3, titles 1; Early (1-3): n=4, avg finish 3.8, playoffs 3/4, top 3 2/4, titles 1; Middle (4-7): n=2, avg finish 6.0, playoffs 1/2, top 3 0/2, titles 0
Caution	Weakest area: Middle (4-7) (avg finish 6.0, n=2).
History	2017: p9, f7; 2018: p9, f3; 2019: p2, f1 champ; 2020: p3, f4; 2021: p2, f8; 2022: p8, f1 champ; 2023: p5, f7; 2024: p2, f2; 2025: p5, f5

Pick Summary Table

Pick	N	Avg Finish	Avg Finish Score	Avg Wins +/-	Avg Points	Top 3	Playoffs	Champs	Saunders
1	9	6.1	0.45	-0.11	0.01	22%	56%	0	11%
2	9	6.6	0.41	0.11	-0.25	33%	44%	1	22%
3	9	6.7	0.37	0.67	0.19	11%	44%	0	11%
4	9	5.6	0.50	-0.11	0.21	11%	67%	0	0%
5	9	5.4	0.52	-0.44	0.04	33%	44%	0	0%
6	9	5.0	0.57	-0.22	-0.01	44%	67%	2	11%
7	9	6.0	0.46	-0.33	-0.13	11%	67%	1	11%
8	9	6.0	0.47	-0.11	-0.36	33%	56%	1	22%
9	9	6.0	0.46	-0.22	-0.51	22%	56%	0	0%
10	9	3.9	0.69	0.89	0.61	56%	78%	3	11%
11	1	1.0	1.00	-1.00	1.08	100%	100%	1	0%
12	1	2.0	0.91	0.00	0.75	100%	100%	0	0%

Zone Summary Table

Zone	N	Avg Pick	Avg Finish	Finish Score	Wins +/-	Points z	Top 3	Playoff	Champion	Saunders
Early (1-3)	27	2.0	6.4	0.41	0.22	-0.02	22%	48%	4%	15%
Middle (4-7)	36	5.5	5.5	0.51	-0.28	0.03	25%	61%	8%	6%
Late (8+)	29	9.2	5.0	0.57	0.14	-0.02	41%	66%	17%	10%

Season-Level Markers

Season	Champion	Champion Pick	Best Regular Season	Pick	Saunders	Pick
2017	Joel	10	Joe	3	Connor	2
2018	Zook	10	Zubs	9	Connor	2
2019	Zubs	2	Joel	1	Nuss	7
2020	Joel	10	Zubs	3	Rishi	1
2021	Joe	6	Joel	10	Plot	3
2022	Zubs	8	Joe	1	Plot	10
2023	Joe	6	Joel	10	Rishi	8
2024	Nuss	7	Zubs	2	Zook	6
2025	Zook	11	Shap	3	Connor	8

Method and Caveats

Scope: only seasons with populated draft_pick values are included. In the current tracker, that is 2017 through 2025. The 2014 through 2016 seasons are excluded from draft-position analysis because draft board data is not present in the dataset.

League-size adjustment: 2025 has 12 teams while the earlier populated seasons have 10. Raw pick number is still shown because it is intuitive, but the report's main score comparisons use normalized finish score and draft percentile.

Interpretation: this is descriptive analysis, not a causal model. Draft order is only one input. Keeper values, injuries, trades, waivers, schedule strength, and scoring environment are not modeled here.

Data note: the report reflects the current SeasonSummary.json values, including the recently added draft positions from board photos. Any image-derived pick that is later corrected in the source data can be incorporated by rerunning this script.